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Tier 1 White-Label Playbook: UK Suppliers Who Will Print Afida's Brand

SUPERSEDED (2026-07-07) after Afida leadership review. The premise was wrong for a supplier: low-MOQ retail-unit printing is a service for end customers (cafés wanting their logo on a cup), not for distributors, and Afida already has a print partner at good rates for that customer-facing work. Distributor own-label in this trade means **plain retail units with branded outer boxes and stamps, imported directly**; Enviropack (an existing Afida trading partner, not a cold lead as assumed here) runs exactly that model. Own-brand therefore goes straight to the direct-import path in the growth plan §5.1. This document is kept for reference: the RFQ question set, compliance checklist (certificate registers, DoC, EN 13432 verification) and pilot-gating logic transfer directly to direct-import due diligence.

Prepared 2026-07-06. Deep-research output: 22 sources fetched, 25 top claims adversarially verified (3 independent votes each) against the suppliers' own live pages on 2026-07-06; 20 confirmed, 5 refuted. Everything below is marked verified, self-declared, or unverified. Companion to §5.1 of the growth plan (docs/reports/growth-plan-2026-2031.md).

The headline

Tier 1 is real and cheaper to start than assumed. At least five UK-based or UK-warehoused suppliers will custom-print their own stocked eco lines under Afida's brand, and for **cups** the printed MOQ floor is **500-1,500 units**, an order of magnitude below converter-scale floors (BioPak: 15,000 per cup size, 200,000 per size for straws and cutlery). A pilot run of Afida-branded double-wall hot cups is a **£500-1,500 decision**, not a £10k one.

The correct sequencing falls straight out of the published MOQs: **cups and boxes first**; napkins, straws and cutlery only later at volume, or printed via a distributor (Agora, Enviropack) rather than a converter.

1. The vetted shortlist

Supplier	Where	Best for	Printed MOQ	Lead time
Agora Food Packaging (VaioPak Group)	UK, national logistics network	Broadest overlap: 100+ printable lines	From 1,000 (most cup/bottle/box lines)	2-4 wks from artwork approval (UK from 2 wks)
Enviropack Ltd	Elstree WD6 3FG, ~5 miles from Afida's Watford base	Local relationship; wide printed range	From 5,000 pieces	Not published
Herald Packaging	Corby NN17 5XZ (UK warehouse)	Design + print + stock-holding ; 700+ lines	Not published ("smaller print runs")	Not published
Scyphus Ltd	Northampton NN7 1AH (UK manufacturer)	Cup specialist, offset print	500-1,000 (free plates from 1,000)	Not published
Nature's Cup (Qualitasse Ltd)	Basingstoke RG22 6PW (UK manufacturer)	Compostable double-wall hot cups (the #1 bestseller category)	~1,000 cups (confirm for printed runs)	Not published
BioPak UK	UK-warehoused	Volume tier only, later	15,000/size cups; 10,000 boxes/bags; 30,000 napkins; 200,000 straws/cutlery	"Fast", free storage

Contacts: Agora 01438 777051 · Enviropack 020 8428 9184, sales@enviropack.org.uk · Herald 0208 507 7900 · Scyphus quote form at scyphuspapercups.co.uk · Nature's Cup via naturescup.co.uk · BioPak sales@biopak.co.uk, 01386 555 777

Supplier notes (what was actually verified)

Agora Food Packaging: best all-round first call. Verified verbatim on their custom-print page: MOQs "start at just 1,000 units for the majority of our cup, bottle and box lines"; lead times "2-4 weeks from the date of artwork approval"; "100+ custom food packaging lines" including single and double-wall hot cups, rPET cold cups, burger boxes, carry bags and printed napkins, i.e. most of Afida's bestseller list in one place. They state EN 13432-certified bagasse lines and a "BRC-certified UK supply chain", but **both are self-declared marketing copy**; ask for certificate numbers.

Enviropack: the local option, worth an in-person visit (Elstree is roughly 5 miles from Watford). Verified: a dedicated custom-branding service ("from logo to full print coverage") with minimums "starting at 5,000 pieces", a published 5-step artwork-to-delivery process, and printed subpages covering double/single-wall, ripple and compostable cups, clear cold cups, napkins, soup and ice-cream containers, deli pots, pizza boxes and paper bags. Companies House 06340579, active since 2007; footer links suggest **Bunzl group ownership** (worth knowing:

the giant's buying power behind a local shopfront, but also a competitor's parent). Caution: a claim about their full stocked-range breadth beyond those printed categories was refuted in verification, so don't assume cutlery/straw/bagasse coverage without asking.

Herald Packaging: the differentiator is verified **stock-holding**: "the team designs, prints, and can even stock-hold your personalised packaging" and "we do smaller print runs and hold stock for customers". That solves Tier 1's storage problem entirely (no pallets in anyone's garage). 700+ lines from a Corby warehouse, covering paper cups, kraft food-on-the-go, bagasse containers and birchwood/cornstarch cutlery. PLA cold cups and napkins are **not** explicitly in their range; MOQs and prices unpublished. Family-run since 1997 (Companies House 03471741). They exhibit at Packaging Innovations (stand J134).

Scyphus: 100% UK cup manufacturer (Companies House 06981300, manufacturing SIC code). Full-colour offset with food-safe inks, in-house design studio, and the best origination deal found anywhere: **free artwork setup and printing plates on all orders from 1,000 cups**; their quote form starts at 500 (4oz espresso cups are an exception at 3,000). Their claim that digital printing inks are not food safe is marketing positioning, not fact (food-compliant low-migration digital inks exist); ignore the rhetoric, keep the free plates.

Nature's Cup: the closest match to the #1 bestseller: compostable double-wall hot cups in 8/12/16oz, manufactured in Hampshire, "own-brand cups for your business in low quantities", minimum 1,000 cups, **under 10p each for 8oz**, which is a useful pricing anchor for every other quote. Two cautions from verification: the 1,000-cup minimum is stated against their standard design with own-design offered in the next sentence (2-1 verification vote), so confirm the printed-run MOQ explicitly; and **no EN 13432 / OK compost certificate is published anywhere on their site**, so compliance documentation is an open question for them specifically.

BioPak UK: wrong tier for now, right tier later. Custom printing on stocked compostable lines with free design work and free storage, but the verified MOQ table (cups 15,000/size, napkins 30,000, straws and cutlery 200,000) makes it relevant only once an Afida-label cup is proven at ~15k+/size velocity. File under Tier 2 trigger.

UniCup: watchlist only, not shortlist. Verified: offset-printed double-wall from 1,000 pcs, and their plastic-free double-wall uses Kotkamills ISLA Duo board with a **DIN CERTCO EN 13432 certificate**, the cleanest example found of compliance sitting upstream at the material level. But they appear to be a Polish manufacturer behind a .co.uk storefront (UK basing unverified, affects lead times, returns and who is importer of record), and their advertised 100-piece digital-label option was **refuted 0-3** in verification. Do not plan around it.

2. The playbook, step by step

Step 1: pick the pilot (one SKU, this month)

12oz double-wall hot cup, the proven bestseller. One size, one design, 1,000-5,000 units. Not a range; the pilot exists to answer "will customers buy the Afida label instead of Vegware", nothing else.

Step 2: prepare the pack before contacting anyone

- Vector logo + simple wrap design (suppliers' in-house studios at Scyphus/Agora/Herald can finish it; don't gold-plate)
- Target spec written down: size, wall type, lining (ask for aqueous/PLA options and their certification status), colours (1-2 colours keeps origination cheap), quantity, delivery postcode

- Current Vegware landed cost per unit for the same SKU, so every quote has a benchmark

Step 3: send the SAME spec to all five, simultaneously

Identical RFQ = comparable quotes. Ask every supplier the same list:

1. Printed MOQ for this exact SKU, and the plain (unprinted) MOQ for contrast
2. Unit price at 1,000 / 5,000 / 10,000, plain vs printed (the delta is the real cost of the brand)
3. Origination: plate/setup fees, per colour, and what's waived at what volume (Scyphus: free from 1,000; hold others to that)
4. Print method (flexo / offset / digital), colour limits, and a physical **printed pre-production sample** policy
5. Lead time from artwork approval, and restock lead time on repeat orders
6. Artwork process: dieline supplied? proof rounds included? who owns the plates?
7. **Certifications, with numbers:** EN 13432 / OK compost certificate number, who holds it (material maker, converter, or them), and written confirmation it covers the **printed** variant (ink type and coverage can narrow or void compostability certification)
8. Food-contact Declaration of Compliance (retained Regulation 1935/2004) naming the printed product, in writing
9. Stock-holding / call-off terms (Herald advertises this; ask everyone)
10. Exclusivity or territory expectations, if any; payment terms; price validity period (board prices move)

Step 4: score and shortlist to two

Score on: printed unit cost vs current Vegware landed cost (the margin uplift must survive the print premium), origination cost, compliance paperwork actually produced (not promised), lead time, and stock-holding. Practitioner sources suggest printed MOQs often run ~2x the plain MOQ and setup fees of roughly £250-700 dominate small-run economics; treat those as negotiation context, not gospel (blog-grade sources).

Step 5: verify compliance before money moves

- Certificate numbers checked against the issuer's public register (TÜV Austria, DIN CERTCO). This matters: verification found that distributor-level EN 13432/BRC statements are **routinely self-declared marketing copy**, and one shortlisted manufacturer publishes no certificate at all.
- Written DoC for the printed product in hand before the PO.
- Afida's own product-page wording drafted against CMA green-claims guidance ("industrially compostable where accepted", not "eco-friendly"); green-claims liability for what afida.com says is Afida's regardless of any supplier paperwork.
- **Open legal item, flagged honestly:** the exact statutory position on food-contact liability when a retailer white-labels a supplier's stocked line was NOT resolved by this research (the one claim on it was refuted in verification). England's food-contact regulations appear to bite on anyone placing product on the market, which would include Afida. Before the first PO, spend an hour with a trade-compliance advisor or the local Trading Standards business service to confirm what documentation Afida must itself hold. Budget line, not blocker.

Step 6: pilot order and an honest test

1,000-5,000 units of the one SKU. Expected pilot spend £500-1,500 including origination (Nature's Cup's sub-10p/8oz anchor and Scyphus's free plates bracket this). Sell it on the same category page alongside the Vegware equivalent at a price that banks half the margin uplift and passes half to the customer. The test: **does the Afida-label cup reach ≥75% of the Vegware**

equivalent's velocity within 8-10 weeks? Track it per-SKU (another reason COGS capture ships this year).

Step 7: decision gate

- Pass → second SKU (8oz double-wall or kraft container), then negotiate repeat pricing and stock-holding; Tier 1 becomes a programme.
- Fail → the brand question is answered cheaply; stay a branded reseller, revisit after the trade-account base grows. No sunk pallets either way.

Optional accelerant

Packaging Innovations, NEC Birmingham (next edition listed 24-25 Feb 2027, Halls 6-9): all-shortlist meetings in one day; Herald confirmed exhibiting (stand J134). Note from verification: the exhibitor directory itself carries no MOQ/print/certification data (a claim it does was refuted), so it is a lead pool and meeting scheduler, nothing more.

3. Pitfalls (each one traced to a verified or refuted finding)

- **Self-declared certificates.** Agora's EN 13432/BRC statements are their own copy; Nature's Cup publishes none; BioPak's custom-print page omits them. Certificate number + issuer register check, every time.
 - **Printing can void the certificate.** A compostability certificate on the plain cup does not automatically cover a printed variant. Get the printed-variant confirmation in writing.
 - **Too-good-to-be-true MOQs.** The one 100-piece option found was refuted on verification. Sub-500 printed cups basically don't exist; anyone offering it is printing a label, not the cup.
 - **Advertised terms are opening positions.** Every MOQ/lead-time/price above is marketing copy verified as *displayed*, not as contracted, on 2026-07-06. Reconfirm at quote.
 - **Range assumptions.** Two range-breadth claims failed verification (Enviropack's full coverage, Celebration Packaging as a candidate). Ask for the specific SKU; never assume from a category menu.
 - **Napkins/straws/cutlery economics.** Converter floors are 30k-200k units. Don't burn credibility asking a converter to print 2,000 napkins; route those through a distributor's print service or leave them branded.
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4. Open questions carried forward

1. Legal: the retailer's food-contact and compliance-documentation obligations when white-labelling (refuted claim; needs a primary-source answer before the first PO).
2. Printed-variant certification: does each supplier's EN 13432 cover Afida-branded print, in whose name?
3. Real numbers nobody publishes: plain-vs-printed price deltas, sample policies, exclusivity terms. Only the same-spec RFQ (Step 3) answers these.
4. UniCup's UK basing and importer-of-record status, if they're ever considered.

Full research trail (104 agents, per-claim votes and sources) in the session workflow journal; key sources: agorafoodpackaging.co.uk, enviropack.org.uk, heraldpackaging.com, scyphuspapercups.co.uk, naturescup.co.uk, biopak.com/uk, unicup.co.uk, packagingbirmingham.com, businesscompanion.info, food.gov.uk, tuv.at.